

Oceania



The widely scattered territories of Oceania stretch across the Pacific Ocean but are home to only 0.5 percent of the world's population. Australia and New Zealand dominate Oceania. In both countries the British colonial legacy remains strong.

Australia



The world's smallest continent, which was colonized by the British in the 18th century.

45000 BCE Archaeological evidence suggests that Aborigines—who crossed over the then land bridge from Southeast Asia—lived in Australia from this time.

1606 Dutch explorer William Jansz goes ashore on the west coast of Cape York.

1642 Dutch explorer Abel Tasman lands in Van Diemen's Land (now Tasmania).

1688 The first British explorer, William Dampier, lands on Australia's northwest coast.

1770 Captain James Cook charts the east coast, landing at Botany Bay. He raises the British flag on an island off Cape York, claiming the territory for Britain.

1788 Eleven ships from Britain land their passengers—including more than 700 convicts—at Port Jackson (now Sydney). Penal colony set up in New South Wales.

1790 Free settlers begin arriving.

1803 Penal colony set up on Van Diemen's Land (later Tasmania).

1813 Explorers first cross the Blue Mountains, part of the Great Dividing Range down the east coast of Australia.

1825 Colony of Van Diemen's Land founded, followed by Western Australia in 1829, South Australia in 1836, Victoria in 1851, and Queensland in 1859.

1828–30 Charles Sturt maps the Murray and Darling river basins; he treks into central Australia in 1844–45.

1840 Transportation of convicts to New South Wales is ended.

1850 British Parliament passes the Australian Colonies Government Act. This allows colonies to set up legislatures.

1851 Gold is discovered at Bathurst in New South Wales and Ballarat in Victoria. The ensuing gold rush attracts thousands.

1853 Transportation from the UK to Tasmania is ended.

1853–67 Transportation is temporarily introduced to Western Australia.

1855 New South Wales, Victoria, South Australia, and Tasmania gain self-government, followed by Queensland in 1859 and Western Australia in 1890.

1859 South Australian government offers a prize to the first person to cross the unexplored continent from south to north. Robert O'Hara Burke and William Wills set out from Melbourne in 1860 and almost reach the north coast, but turn back and die on the way home in 1861.

1861 After two previous attempts, John McDouall Stuart sets out from Adelaide and reaches Darwin in the north in 1862.

1891 The first Australian Federal Convention meets. Delegates draw up a draft constitution to federate the states.

1901 The Commonwealth of Australia comes into being. A parliament is created with a House of Representatives and a Senate. The British monarch is head of state and appoints a Governor-General. The Immigration Restriction Act limits non-European immigration, beginning the "White Australia Policy."

1911 Canberra founded as federal capital.

1914–18 Australia fights with Britain and its allies in World War I. Its troops capture German colonies in the Pacific and fight in Turkey and Europe.



Canberra

Rivalry between Melbourne and Sydney led to the decision in 1911 to build a new national capital midway between the two. Building began in 1923 and the federal parliament (above) opened in 1927.

1915 Australian troops suffer heavy casualties at Gallipoli in Turkey.

1929 Industrial upheaval and financial collapse caused by the Great Depression.

1939 Prime Minister Robert Menzies announces that Australia will follow the UK into war with Germany.

1942 Fall of Singapore to Japanese army. As a Japanese invasion of Australia seems imminent, the government turns to the US for help.

1950–53 Australian troops committed to UN forces fighting in Korea against North Korean communists.

1951 ANZUS military assistance treaty is signed with the US. Under the treaty, Australia is committed to participate in the Vietnam War in the 1960s.

1956 Olympic Games held in Melbourne.

1962 Menzies government commits Australian aid to war in Vietnam.

1966 Adopts decimal currency.

1967 Aborigines are granted full citizenship rights, but their land rights are not recognized.

1972 Gough Whitlam is elected as Labour prime minister and ceases aid to South Vietnam.

1975 Whitlam government dismissed by Governor-General Sir John Kerr for failing to gain parliamentary approval for the national budget. Malcolm Fraser forms coalition government.

1992 Paul Keating replaces Bob Hawke as Labour prime minister and announces a "Turning toward Asia" policy.

1993 After the High Court's Mabo Judgment had recognized Aboriginal rights in 1992, the Native Title Act provides compensation for Aboriginal rights extinguished by existing land title.

AUSTRALIA

EXTERNAL TERRITORIES

AUSTRALIAN ANTARCTIC TERRITORY
1933 Set up under imperial order.

COCOS (KEELING) ISLANDS

Two atolls in the western Indian Ocean.
1609 Discovered by William Keeling.
1857 Britain annexes the islands.
1955 Transferred to Australia.

CHRISTMAS ISLAND

Isolated peak in the Indian Ocean.
1888 Annexed by Britain.
1957 Transferred to Australia.

NORFOLK ISLAND

Island off east coast of Australia.
1788–1814, 1825–56 Penal colony.
1913 Designated an Australian Territory.

HEARD & McDONALD ISLANDS

Remote islands in south Indian Ocean.
1947 Britain gives islands to Australia.

ASHMORE & CARTIER ISLANDS

Islands in the Indian Ocean.
1933 Designated an Australian Territory.

CORAL SEA ISLANDS

A group of islands off northeast coast.
1969 Designated an Australian territory.

1996 Liberal John Howard becomes prime minister. The shooting of 35 people by a gunman in Port Arthur, Tasmania, prompts tightening of gun control laws.

1999 Referendum rejects proposals to replace Queen Elizabeth II as head of state by a president elected by parliament.

2000 Olympic Games are held in Sydney.

2002 Eighty-eight Australian tourists are killed in Bali bombings by Islamists.

2003 Troops are deployed in the Gulf, provoking protests. The Senate passes a no-confidence motion against Howard for his handling of the Iraq crisis.

2006 A deal is signed with East Timor over oil and gas rights in the Timor Sea.

2007 The Labour Party under Kevin Rudd win landslide election victory. Rudd signs the Kyoto Protocol, reversing the policy of the previous Liberal PM John Howard.

2008 The government apologizes for past wrongs done to indigenous population.

2009 Bushfires in Victoria kill 180 people.

2010 Kevin Rudd resigns as prime minister. Julia Gillard becomes first female prime minister and narrowly wins subsequent election, forming a minority administration—the first since 1942.

«290–91 The Food Revolution
«320–21 Completing the Map
«350–51 Colonial Resistance